Developmental Foundations of Tangible Interactive Learning Systems for Early Childhood:

The Böðn Project

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Abstract

Böðn is an open-source, battery-powered tangible learning system designed for children aged 3–7. The device combines physical controls (buttons, rotary encoders, toggle switches) with multimodal feedback (LED animations, synthesized audio, screen graphics) to deliver play experiences that target core executive functions—working memory, inhibitory control, and cognitive flexibility—as well as sensorimotor, cognitive, language, and social-emotional development. This paper reviews the developmental science that informs Böðn's design, maps each feature to established developmental domains, and identifies areas for future development. We argue that tangible interfaces offer advantages over touchscreen-only systems for early childhood learning, and that game-based, guided play can meaningfully support executive function development during the critical preschool window.

Keywords: executive functions, tangible user interfaces, early childhood, guided play, physical computing, open-source hardware

Contents

1 Introduction **3**

2 Background **3**

2.1 Executive Functions in Early Childhood 3

2.2 Guided Play and Playful Learning 4

2.3 Tangible User Interfaces for Young Children 4

2.4 Multimodal Feedback and Sensory Integration 4
2.5 Auditory Processing and Musical Exposure 5
2.6 Bilingualism and Executive Function 5
2.7 Pretend Play and Social-Cognitive Development 5
2.8 Feedback, Failure, and Growth Mindset 5

3 System Design **5**
3.1 Hardware Architecture 5
3.2 Software Architecture 6

4 Developmental Analysis **6**
4.1 Feature–Domain Mapping 6
4.1.1 Simon (Härmapa) 6
4.1.2 Rule Follow (Regelleken) 6
4.1.3 Mystery Box (Mysterium) 7
4.1.4 Flöde 7
4.1.5 Garden of Life (Trädgården) 7
4.1.6 Soundboard (Ljudbräda) 7
4.1.7 Spaceship Cockpit (Rymdskepp) 7
4.2 Coverage Matrix 7
4.3 Gap Analysis 7

5 Discussion **9**
5.1 Tangible Interfaces vs. Touchscreen Applications 9
5.2 Adaptive Difficulty and the Zone of Proximal Development 9
5.3 Feedback Design and Growth Mindset 9
5.4 Session Limits and Healthy Technology Use 9
5.5 Limitations 9

6 Future Work **9**

7 Conclusion **10**

1 Introduction

The preschool years (ages 3–7) represent a critical period for the development of executive functions (EF)—the cognitive control processes that enable goal-directed behaviour (Diamond, 2013). A large body of evidence links early EF to school readiness (Blair and Razza, 2007), social competence, and lifelong well-being (Moffitt et al., 2011). Unlike IQ, which is relatively stable, executive functions are highly malleable during early childhood and respond to targeted practice (Diamond, 2013; Montroy et al., 2016).

At the same time, the proliferation of touchscreen devices has raised concerns about passive screen time in young children (Radesky et al., 2015). The World Health Organization recommends no more than one hour of sedentary screen time per day for children aged 2–4 (World Health Organization, 2019). This creates a tension: digital systems can deliver adaptive, engaging practice that physical toys cannot, yet the medium itself may undermine the developmental benefits.

Tangible user interfaces (TUI)—physical objects that bridge the digital and physical worlds—offer a potential resolution. Since Ishii and Ullmer (1997) introduced the concept, a growing literature has explored TUI for educational contexts, finding advantages in engagement, spatial understanding, and embodied learning (Marshall, 2007; Price et al., 2003).

This paper presents **Böðn**, an open-source tangible learning system that combines physical controls with adaptive, game-based experiences designed around the developmental science of early childhood. We review the theoretical foundations, describe the system design, map each feature to developmental domains, and identify directions for future work.

2 Background

2.1 Executive Functions in Early Childhood

Miyake et al. (2000) proposed the influential three-factor model of executive functions: *working memory* (updating), *inhibitory control* (inhibition), and *cognitive flexibility* (shifting). While originally validated in adults, subsequent work has confirmed this structure in preschoolers, with important developmental nuances (Montroy et al., 2016).

Working memory is the ability to hold and manipulate information in mind. In 4-year-olds, typical capacity is 2–4 items (Diamond, 2013). Tasks like remembering a sequence of coloured lights and reproducing it from memory directly exercise this capacity.

Inhibitory control encompasses both response inhibition (suppressing a prepotent motor response) and interference control (resisting distracting information). The classic "day–night" task, where children must say "night" when shown a sun card, illustrates the

challenge for preschoolers (Diamond, 2013).

Cognitive flexibility requires disengaging from one rule set and engaging a new one. The Dimensional Change Card Sort (DCCS) task (Zelazo, 2006) is the standard assessment: children sort cards first by colour, then by shape. Most 3-year-olds fail the switch; most 5-year-olds succeed. The transition period (ages 3–5) represents a critical window for practice.

2.2 Guided Play and Playful Learning

Weisberg et al. (2013) define guided play as adult-scaffolded activities where children explore within a structured environment designed to make discovery productive. Guided play occupies a middle ground between free play (child-directed, no adult structure) and direct instruction (adult-directed, no child agency). Evidence suggests that guided play produces deeper learning than either extreme for concept acquisition and problem-solving (Hirsh-Pasek et al., 2015).

2.3 Tangible User Interfaces for Young Children

Ishii and Ullmer (1997) introduced the concept of tangible user interfaces as a way to "give physical form to digital information." For young children, who are still developing fine motor skills and abstract thinking, the physical affordances of tangible interfaces offer several advantages over touchscreens:

- **Embodied interaction**: Physical manipulation engages motor planning, proprioception, and spatial reasoning simultaneously (Price et al., 2003).
- **Reduced cognitive load**: Physical affordances (a button looks pressable, a knob looks turnable) reduce the interface learning burden, freeing cognitive resources for content (Marshall, 2007).
- **Multimodal feedback**: Tactile confirmation (button click, encoder detent) combines with visual and auditory feedback to strengthen sensorimotor associations.

2.4 Multimodal Feedback and Sensory Integration

Young children benefit from redundant, multimodal feedback—receiving the same information through multiple sensory channels simultaneously (Price et al., 2003). In Böðn, every user action produces visual (LED/screen), auditory (tone/sound), and tactile (physical click/detent) feedback. This redundancy:

- Strengthens cross-modal neural connections
- Provides confirmation even if one channel is missed
- Supports different learning preferences and sensory profiles

2.5 Auditory Processing and Musical Exposure

Early exposure to structured sound environments supports auditory processing skills that underpin language acquisition and musical development (Kraus and Chandrasekaran, 2010; Trainor, 2005). Active sound production (as opposed to passive listening) is particularly effective.

2.6 Bilingualism and Executive Function

A substantial literature documents enhanced executive functions in bilingual children, attributed to the constant need to manage two active language systems (Bialystok, 2011). The bilingual advantage is most pronounced for inhibitory control and cognitive flexibility—the same skills that Böðn's game modes target.

2.7 Pretend Play and Social-Cognitive Development

Lillard et al. (2013) reviewed the evidence linking pretend play to cognitive development, finding associations with theory of mind, narrative skills, and emotional understanding. While the causal direction remains debated, the correlational evidence is strong, and pretend play is universally observed across cultures during the preschool years.

2.8 Feedback, Failure, and Growth Mindset

Dweck (2006) distinguishes between fixed mindset (ability is innate) and growth mindset (ability develops through effort). The type of feedback children receive after failure shapes which mindset they develop. Process-focused feedback ("You tried a different strategy, good!") promotes growth mindset; outcome-focused feedback ("Wrong!") promotes fixed mindset.

Böðn's feedback design follows this principle: errors produce soft, warm cues (gentle tone, dim red glow) rather than punitive signals. The intent is to frame failure as information, not judgement.

3 System Design

3.1 Hardware Architecture

Böðn is built around an ESP32-S3 microcontroller with the following physical interface components:

- 8 mini push buttons (colour-coded, via MCP23017 I2C expander)
- 5 arcade buttons with PWM-controlled LEDs (via PCA9685)

- 2 toggle switches (via MCP23017)
- 3 rotary encoders with push buttons (navigation, volume, throttle)
- 2.8" ILI9341 TFT primary display (240×320, landscape)
- 1.8" ST7735 TFT secondary display (128×160, portrait)
- 2× WS2812 8-LED sticks + 92-LED perimeter strip (RGB)
- MAX98357A I2S amplifier with 3W speaker
- INMP441 I2S MEMS microphone
- 6600 mAh LiPo battery with thermal monitoring (DS18B20×2)

3.2 Software Architecture

The firmware is written in MicroPython and follows a modular architecture:

- **Rule engines** (`*_rules.py`): Pure logic modules with no hardware dependencies, testable via standard pytest on the host.
- **Screen modules** (`ui/*.py`): Render game state to displays and LEDs; handle input events.
- **Audio engine**: 6-voice mixer with priority channels (music, SFX pool, UI feedback).
- **Session manager**: Enforces play time limits, breaks, and quiet hours.
- **i18n system**: All user-facing strings localised (Swedish default, English available).

4 Developmental Analysis

This section maps each Böðn feature to established developmental domains and analyses coverage. Table 1 presents the full feature–domain matrix.

4.1 Feature–Domain Mapping

4.1.1 Simon (Härmapa)

The Simon memory game directly targets **working memory** capacity. The starting sequence length of 2 items is calibrated to the lower bound of 4-year-old WM capacity (Diamond, 2013). Each successful round adds one item, providing adaptive difficulty within the child's zone of proximal development (Vygotsky, 1978).

4.1.2 Rule Follow (Regelleken)

Modelled after the DCCS task (Zelazo, 2006), Rule Follow alternates between "match" and "opposite" rules. The "opposite" rule requires **inhibitory control** (suppressing the prepotent matching response), while the rule switch exercises **cognitive flexibility**. The

frequency of rule switches (every 4–6 correct answers) is within the range used in DCCS research.

4.1.3 Mystery Box (Mysterium)

An open-ended **cause-and-effect** exploration mode with no failure state. The design follows the "guided play" model (Weisberg et al., 2013): the environment is structured (specific button–colour mappings, discoverable combinations) but the child's exploration is entirely self-directed.

4.1.4 Flöde

A **spatial reasoning** and **problem-solving** puzzle that requires aligning gaps in vertical walls. The snap-to-grid mechanic reduces motor precision demands while preserving the cognitive challenge.

4.1.5 Garden of Life (Trädgården)

A **pattern recognition** mode based on Conway's Game of Life. The child plants coloured seeds and observes emergent behaviour—an implicit introduction to complex systems and self-organisation. The mode exercises no executive functions but provides rich visual stimulation and cause-and-effect learning.

4.1.6 Soundboard (Ljudbräda)

An **auditory processing** and **open exploration** mode. Customisable sound banks allow parents to create themed experiences. The volume encoder provides fine motor practice with immediate auditory feedback.

4.1.7 Spaceship Cockpit (Rymdskepp)

The most developmentally comprehensive mode, targeting **cognitive flexibility** (5 scenario types requiring different inputs), **listening comprehension** (TTS-driven instructions), and **imaginative play** (structured pretend-play as a spaceship captain). The adaptive difficulty system adjusts timeout windows based on the child's recent performance, maintaining an appropriate challenge level.

4.2 Coverage Matrix

4.3 Gap Analysis

The matrix reveals strong coverage for executive functions, visual processing, and open exploration. Areas with limited coverage include:

Table 1: Feature–developmental domain coverage matrix. ● ● ● = primary target; ●● = significant; ● = incidental; blank = not applicable.

Domain	*Simon*	*Rule Follow*	*Mystery Box*	*Flöde*	*Garden*	*Soundboard*	*Spaceship*
Working memory	● ● ●	●●		●			●●
Inhibitory control	●	● ● ●					●●
Cognitive flexibility		● ● ●					● ● ●
Cause & effect			● ● ●		●●	●●	
Pattern recognition	●●		●●		● ● ●		
Spatial reasoning				● ● ●			
Sequential thinking	● ● ●			●●			
Problem solving				● ● ●			●
Fine motor	●	●	●	●●	●	●	●●
Hand–eye coord.	●●	●●		●●			●●
Auditory processing	●●					● ● ●	●●
Visual processing	●●	●●	● ● ●	●●	● ● ●		●●
Listening comp.						●	● ● ●
Bilingual exposure	●	●		●	●	●	●
Self-regulation	●●	● ● ●			●		●●
Persistence	●●	●		● ● ●			●
Imaginative play							● ● ●
Open exploration			● ● ●		● ● ●	● ● ●	
Divergent thinking			● ● ●		●●		
Creative expression					●●	● ● ●	

1. **Spatial reasoning**: Currently addressed only by Flöde. A tangram or construction mode would add breadth.
2. **Listening comprehension**: Only the Spaceship mode exercises active listening. A story or audio scavenger hunt mode could strengthen this domain.
3. **Bilingual exposure**: Currently passive (UI labels). An active language-switching game would be more impactful, leveraging the bilingual advantage for EF development (Bialystok, 2011).
4. **Imaginative play**: Only the Spaceship mode provides structured pretend play. Additional narrative modes could expand this.
5. **Creative expression**: Primarily addressed by Soundboard and Garden. The planned Sequencer mode will significantly strengthen this area.

5 Discussion

5.1 Tangible Interfaces vs. Touchscreen Applications

5.2 Adaptive Difficulty and the Zone of Proximal Development

5.3 Feedback Design and Growth Mindset

5.4 Session Limits and Healthy Technology Use

5.5 Limitations

6 Future Work

1. **Empirical validation**: Conduct pre–post studies comparing EF measures (DCCS, digit span) in children using Böðn vs. control activities.

2. **Sequencer mode**: Implement the planned sequencing mode to strengthen creative expression and computational thinking (cf. Papert 1980).

3. **Cooperative play**: Add turn-taking and collaborative modes to support social-cognitive development.

4. **Adaptive difficulty modelling**: Implement Bayesian difficulty estimation to maintain each child in their zone of proximal development across play sessions.

5. **Longitudinal tracking**: Use the existing session logging infrastructure to track developmental progress over months and years.

6. **Active bilingual features**: Develop language-switching games that leverage the bilingual EF advantage.

7 Conclusion

Böðn demonstrates that tangible, open-source hardware can deliver developmentally informed play experiences for young children. By grounding each feature in established developmental science—particularly the executive function literature—and by providing physical controls rather than touchscreen interaction, the system aims to combine the adaptability of digital systems with the developmental benefits of hands-on play. The open-source design invites collaboration from educators, developmental psychologists, and the maker community to extend and validate the approach.

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